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The Meaning, Importance and Process of Making Apology

Types of Apology

1. POLITE APOLOGY	**4. SYMPATHETIC "APOLOGY" (cf. "partial apology")**
2. PSEUDO-APOLOGY	**5. PERSONAL, MORAL APOLOGY (cf. "full apology")**
3. PREMATURE APOLOGY	**6. PUBLIC, FORMAL APOLOGY**

1. POLITE APOLOGY • "Beg your pardon!" • "Sorry to interrupt you, but…" • "Apologies for having to leave early today." • "We regret any inconvenience caused by the postponement of this flight."	**4. SYMPATHETIC "APOLOGY"** • "I am really sorry that things worked out this way." • "I'm sorry for what you've been through; it has been terrible." • "I'm sorry to hear your father passed away." • "I'm sorry your wife is unwell." • "I am sorry your arm was broken; it was an accident."
2. PSEUDO-APOLOGY • "I'm sorry you found my behaviour so upsetting." • "I'm sorry if you have been offended." • "I'm sorry you took it the wrong way." • "In hindsight, mistakes were made." • "I regret any injuries that may have occurred." • "It's not really my fault, but I apologize anyway."	**5. PERSONAL, MORAL APOLOGY** • "I apologise for speaking that way to you; I should not have done so." • "I'm sorry for not contacting you earlier; I should have remembered." • "I apologise for hurting you; it won't happen again." • "What happened was wrong, and I'm sorry for my part in causing it."
3. PREMATURE APOLOGY • "I'm sorry for everything. Let's just forget about it and move on." • "Sorry, sorry, sorry, OK then?"	**6. PUBLIC, FORMAL APOLOGY** Made by a representative body to a broad audience, acknowledging responsibility for harm and offering repair

Apology Needs of Harmed Party

Need	Meaning
1. Respect:	The offence is often experienced as disrespectful (cf. "dissed") – viz., a disregard of the person's value or dignity or equality. At worst, the offended party feels humiliated or shamed. Hence he or she needs a restoration of respect and affirmation of their dignity.
2. Shared Values:	The offence breaches the Golden Rule. The offended party needs the offender to reaffirm their commitment to the common values and norms that enable them to live together safely.
3. Vindication:	The injured party needs reassurance that they were not primarily to blame for the incident; that responsibility for the harm rests elsewhere. They need to have their innocence vindicated.
4. Validation:	The offence has caused distress, and offended party needs to know the offender has understood their anguish and regrets causing it. Hence, the harmed party needs an opportunity to communicate their experience and have it acknowledged.
5. Reciprocity of suffering:	As an experience of undeserved suffering, the injured party needs to know offender also experiences some pain (e.g., by feeling remorse; by making sacrifices to make compensation; by undergoing retributive punishment).
6. Repair:	Where possible, the offended party needs to have their actual losses made good and damage repaired. Sometimes this is essential to the apology; at other times repair is not possible, except at a moral or symbolic level.
7. Release:	The injured party needs to be able to let go of their bitterness or resentment or sense of grievance, as means of gaining freedom from being controlled by the memory of offence or offender.

Apology Motivations of Offending Party

Need	Explanation
1. Need to assuage their conscience (internal moral drive)	Drive to relieve inner feelings of guilt and shame; to live up to one's self-image as decent, caring person.
2. Need to renegotiate the relationship (external, relational drive)	Drive to restore balance or peace or equity to the relationship, or to avoid painful consequences, such as tit for tat retribution.
3. Other goals?	

Elements of a Full Apology

Element	*Explanation*
1. RECOGNITION:	Acknowledging the offence, identifying the parties who have been injured, and recognizing its impact on them.
2. RESPONSIBILITY:	Admitting responsibility for the offence, whether intentional or unintentional, cf. "It was my fault" or "I am partly to blame."
3. REMORSE:	An inner feeling of painful regret about the offence, which is communicated in some recognizable way to the injured party.
4. REASONS:	An explanation of what happened and the reasons for one's actions, cf. "You owe me an explanation!"
5. REMEDY:	A willingness to do what is needed to repair the damage, perhaps symbolically, cf. "What can I do to make it up to you?"
6. REASSURANCE:	Resolving to refrain from such behaviour in the future, thus reassuring the injured party of a commitment to shared values and future safety, cf. "It won't happen again."
7. REQUEST:	Asking, perhaps implicitly, for forgiveness (release from resentment) and renewed trust in the relationship (the Golden Rule).